Neologisms: New and Improved

Marc Alexander · English Language & Linguistics 2A · Week 5

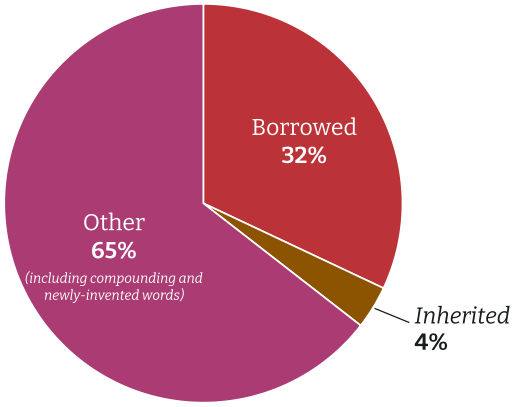


FIGURE 1 Pie chart of the sources of English words: Borrowed 32%, Inherited 4%, Other (including compounding and newly-invented words) 65%

*not a **real** word*

*a '**made-up**' word*

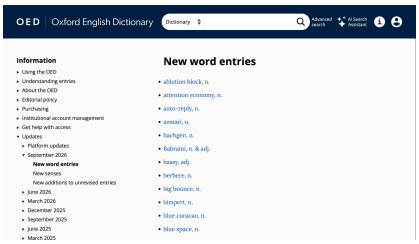


FIGURE 2 The OED's list of new word entries for September 2026, from ablution block to blue space

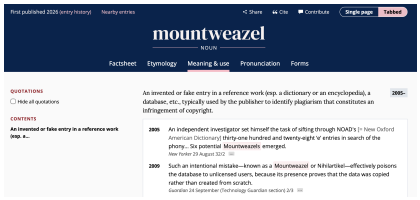


FIGURE 3 The OED entry for mountweazel, noun: an invented or fake entry in a reference work, used by the publisher to identify plagiarism, first published 2026

Neologisms: How Do We Get New Words?

1 Affixation

English affixes are used to create a **non-transparent** new word.

- *graceful/disgraceful*
- *spectacle/spectacles*
- *new/news*
- *hard/hardly*

2 Conversion

Take a word form from another part of speech.

- *access*
- *email*
- *fish*
- *smooth*
- *gaatekeep*
- *convict*
- *present*
- *refuse*
- *torment*
- *record, rebel*

3 Compounding

English **bases** are compounded together.

hovercraft	
bonfire	
holiday	
woman	
goodbye	
lord	
hussy	

4 De novo

Entirely new word invented by putting together letters/sounds.

- *flabbergast*
- *gizmo*
- *Muppet*
- *Kodak*
- *Quark*
- *Jedi*
- *Viagra*
- *Prozac*
- *Nylon*

5 Blending *(portmanteau)*

Taking parts of two words and merging them

brunch	
sitcom	
romantasy	
blog	
examnesia	
tradwife	

6 Clipping

A shortened form of a word becomes a word in its own right.

flu	
hyper	
copter	
sci-fi	
gin	
rizz	

7 Back-formation

Creation of words by (mistaken) analogy.

- *to burgle*
- *to buttle*
- *cherry*
- *grovel*

8 Abbrev.

Taking the first letters, the first sounds, or the first few letters of words and combining them into a new word.

ACRONYMS

- *Nasa*
- *Shape*
- *Nato*
- *Laser*
- *Radar*
- *Modem*
- *Jeep*
- *Potus/Scotus*
- *Fubar/Snafu*
- *Lol (LOL?)*

INITIALISMS

- *FDR*
- *BBC*
- *UK*
- *AM/PM*
- *BC/AD*
- *CE/BCE*
- *MA/PhD*
- *LOL (Lol?)*
- *FAQ (Faq?)*
- *LLM*

9 Eponyms

Words from names.

- *watt*
- *kelvin*
- *boycott*
- *cardigan*
- *lynch*
- *nicotine*
- *cheddar*
- *denim*
- *port*
- *sherry*
- *atlas*
- *morphine/morph*
- *panic*
- *to Instagram*

10 Onomatopoeia

Emulating a sound in a word.

- *woof*
- *baa / bleat*
- *quack*
- *roar*
- *burble*
- *meow*
- *bang*
- *cuckoo*

11 Reduplication

When part or all of a word is repeated.

- *hip-hop*
- *bonbon*
- *ping-pong*
- *itty-bitty*
- *mish-mash*
- *fifty-fifty*